a fundamental part in the outbreak and sustainment of political conflict and war by motivating (good) men to fight in order to protect (innocent) women, and by situating women as symbols and signifiers of the ethnic nation-state (Elshtain 1987). A gender analysis would reveal how this results in Kachin women experiencing and responding to the conflict in ways that are gender-specific and that have implications for political violence.

Despite a paucity of work in Myanmar studies incorporating a gender perspective, there are some notable exceptions. Mi Mi Khaing's early work on the family and the status of Burmese women was one of the first such accounts to be published in English (1946, 1984), highlighting the role of women in education, employment, politics, religion, and society at large. Her books are largely descriptive and do not employ feminist theories to explore gender roles. However, she does note that women's pervasive exclusion from political office is often "disguised as protectiveness" (1984, p. 150), a point still significant today. Historian Chie Ikeya's study (2011) on how women's bodies were used in colonial Myanmar to signify resistance to or support of nationalism have informed this chapter's argument that the construction of femininity is important for understanding conflict and nation-making narratives. Of particular interest is her analysis of how the notion of Burmese women's 'high status' has been manipulated by political elites to masquerade for the continued exclusion of women from leadership roles (Ikeya 2005, p. 51; also see Than 2014).

The centrality of gender for the British colonial project has similarly been emphasized by scholars Jonathan Saha (2010, 2013), and Nick Cheesman (2013). They both show how constructions of femininity and masculinity were filtered through lenses of race and ethnicity and used by colonial officials to rationalize and justify decisions taken, such as for meting out justice and enforcing concepts of social order. For example, Saha shows how women, from the very commencement of the colonial project, were seen as symbolizing both the colonial and the colonized collective (see also Yuval-Davis and Anthias 1989). Therefore, norms regarding gender and sexuality, framed as related to women's positioning in relation to 'their' ethnic group, served to inform court rulings on gender-based violence (Saha 2010). These ideas still hold relevance today, not least in narratives of sexual violence, which are similarly filtered through ethnic lenses and prevalent in discussions on the Kachin conflict. Finally, Jessica Harriden's (2012) account of the relationship between conceptualizations of power and gender in Myanmar as explaining the lack of female representation